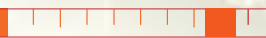


SKOAR! Special



THE SKOAR  8.5

BATTLEFIELD BAD COMPANY 2

Developer: EA DICE

Publisher: EA Games

Platform: PC, X-Box 360

Price: 999 (PC)

We got Company Cap'n

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Ever since I played Battlefield 1943 and later Battlefield 2142, I wasn't a huge fan. Sure, the multiplayer action was good – vehicular combat is always nice, but overlarge maps meant you needed to have at least 16 players to make things fun. Bad Company 2 therefore, had more than big boots to fill. It had to make a believer out of me. Which meant a robust single player campaign, great gameplay (which was also lacking in its predecessors) and an involving multiplayer component. After playing offline for around 12 hours and two bursts of four hours each online, I'm happy to report that DICE did a good job – Bad Company 2 is just the opposite of its name and will keep you good company over a leisurely weekend and then some.

The engine is beautiful with a lot of physics and particle effects. Although the environs aren't as large scale and open-ended as any of the *S.T.A.L.K.E.R* games or *Crysis*, there is definitely a feeling of space, but not unnecessarily extra space, except where you need to travel by vehicle to reach waypoints scattered across a large map. Sunlight, HDR and bloom are a little overblown at times, though dappled shadows and reflections have been done well. Talking about

physics, environments meaning mostly buildings are destructible and this makes for a lot of eye-candy. Even firefights leave a lot of debris and smoke. Not only does this make for a beautiful viewing experience, it's also more realistic and makes tactical sense. A sniper in a watchtower can be taken out by shooting through the wooden planks, grenade the tower, thereby destroying it or waiting for him to pop up and sniping him with a headshot of your own. Water is done exceptionally well – as well as or even better than *Crysis* in my opinion. The sound component is really good – aural clues are a great help in combat and the sound component is spot on.

You'll play Marlowe and the deadly quartet of Sarge, Sweetwater, Haggard and yourself are back. The team is as verbose as ever and this keeps things in a lighter vein at times. The action is frenetic though, and enemies come in droves of anywhere between three and twenty – you'll need to put your most tactical foot forward. Advancing on an enemy position can be imposing. AI accuracy is eerily unerring and enemies have pretty much the same weaponry, meaning a couple of well-placed shots bring about your demise easily. You'll have an arsenal to choose from – assault rifles, machine guns, shotguns, sniper rifles, rocket launches – the number of collectable weapons is mind-boggling. Blood

and gore levels are a little weak, why be biased I say? You can destroy walls but your M60 cannot shoot off arms and legs – killjoy, literally. Vehicular combat is quite a treat, you'll bounce around in a Hummer, roll about in an M1 Abrams and fire hellcat missiles from a chopper. One of the irritants is your team simply refuses to finish some opponents off – it's annoying to find your team mate emptying six rounds into an opponent only to have him stagger and recover when one shot from you puts him down. Your squad is also nigh indestructible.

Multiplayer comprises of up to 24 players in a variety of scenarios like Rush, Conquest and Squad Deathmatch. Earning points allows you to unlock additional gear, some of which is class specific. Classes are soldier, engineer, medics and snipers.

Bad Company 2 isn't the system hog I expected it to be, but it requires a powerful machine to run it at high detail with goodies like AA enabled. It'll run on a GeForce 9600GT too, but you'll be missing out on a lot of eye-candy and essential elements like destructible environs will be minimised. If you have a GTX 260 or equivalent ATI card, you're covered. If you have a Core i7 with a dual GPU setup or a very high-end card – you'll be able to play the game in all its visual glory, and having tried this, I can tell you the investment is worth it. 